# Consistent urban design language for the Maldives

*draft by public policy lab for ADB – 9 July 2025*

A well-defined urban design language can be key to developing a consistent visual aesthetic for cities. This contributes to a stronger sense of place and identity, and improves the aesthetic experience for both residents and visitors. There are cities and towns with much smaller populations which nonetheless have a distinct and recognizable aesthetic that can be immediately recognized by tourists, such as Santorini in Greece with its universally white-washed buildings. Santorini has a clear visual identity with a lot of consistency in colour, pattern, and form. This visual identity is directly related to the history and environment of the country, with white buildings and more classical forms being harmonious with people's image of Greek statues and buildings.

A distinct urban aesthetic creates an instant, marketable mental image for tourists, encouraging them to spend time exploring the cities rather than just transiting to resorts immediately. Currently, Male' City and Maldivian urban areas in general don't have a formally recognized consistent visual language or set of guiding principles, even for government buildings. A modern architectural aesthetic in Male' City is characterized by blocky, single-color, shiny panel styled buildings. The bright, uniform colour panel design of prominent buildings having become a common architectural and aesthetic motif in Male' City building development highlights the lack of an existing set of coherent guidelines around design which incorporates harmonious connection to the history and environment of the Maldives.

## Building toward a consistent visual language

A clear set of principles and guidelines laying out a consistent visual language can be finalized and created with input from architects, cultural experts, historians, city planners, local tourism bodies, ministries such as the Ministry of Construction and the Ministry of Tourism, city councils, and other stakeholders.

Government-designed and public buildings can, as a rule, follow the guidelines going forward, and renovation or upgrades of existing buildings by government can follow these guidelines in cases where design choices need to be made. These guidelines can be disseminated and encouraged for architecture firms and private developers, and included within the bid requirements for government-developed buildings.

DRAFT

## What could constitute a Maldivian urban design language?

Three historical buildings next to each other in the heart of Male' City can provide a foundation for an urban design language for Male' City. The most direct and basic "core principle" for the guidelines could use the Medhuziyaaraiy / Munnaaru / Hukuru Miskiyy historical complex as the architectural touchstone, with other elements woven in.

- The color palettes and design elements of white with blue blocks or patterns
- Materials like weathered or bleached stone and varnished woods
- Patterns based on Islamic geometric patterns like those in Hukuru Miskiyy or coconut leaf cross-thatching and weaving patterns from traditional craft

| Core design touchstones from Medhuziyaaraiy and Hukuru Miskiyy complex | |
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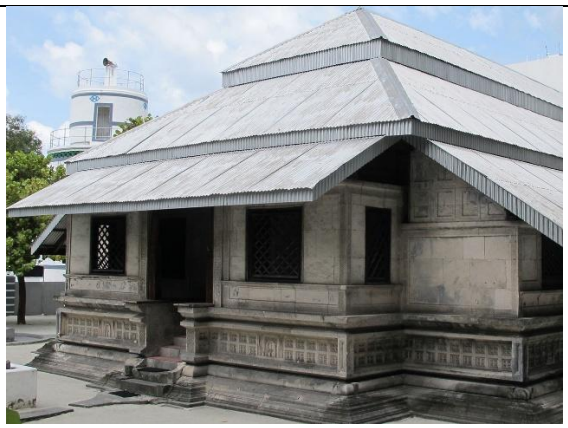

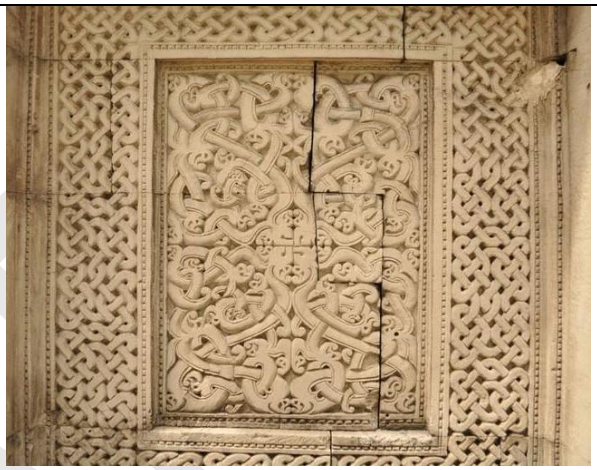

Other elements include:

- Stripes and lines of blacks, whites, and reds or gold filigree styles from designs such as liyela, feyli, and libaas as design accents
- For nature-inspired exteriors, facades, or wall designs, referencing significant local flora and fauna such as:
    - patterns of coconut palm fronds
    - the wavy lines and textures of banana leaves
    - the fan-like clusters and curved design of Magoo plants (sea lettuce, universal on beaches in the Maldives)
    - the forms of banyan, hirundhu, breadfruit, and jackfruit trees
    - the colour burst patterns of pink bougainvillea.

Some modern patterns and motifs that have become instantly recognizable with Male' City can also provide some inspiration for more avant garde or modern designs.

- Grey interlocking pavement blocks
- Tetrapod breakwaters, can provide some inspiration when creating a consistent visual aesthetic across the city.
- Standardized typography – almost all formal Dhivehi language including in public signs and documents is in Faruma font, but also standardizing all public typography in English. For example, the standard Arial(?) font used in all Hulhumale road signs.

| Other inspirations for visual language | |
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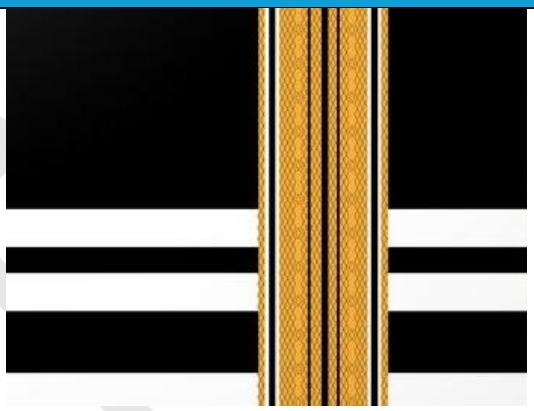
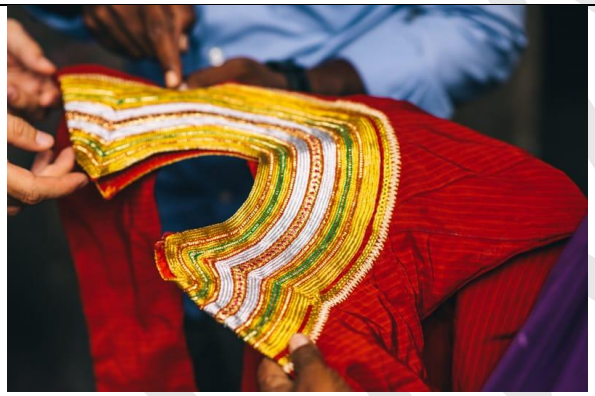
| |  |
|  | |
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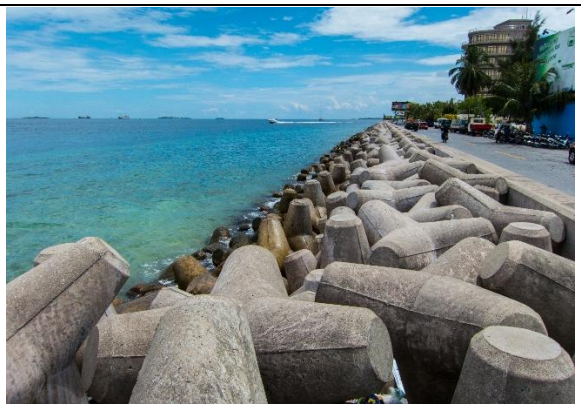
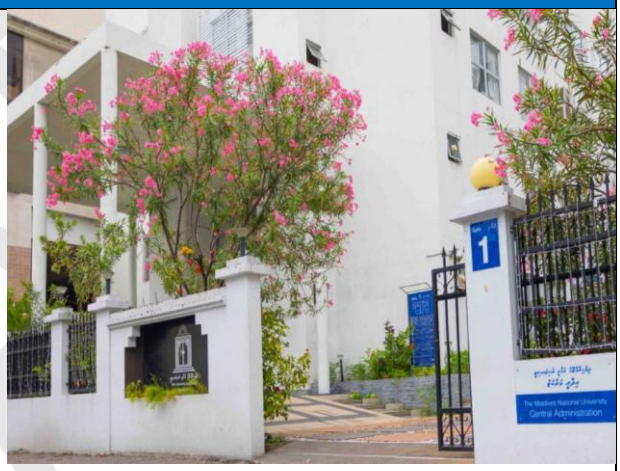


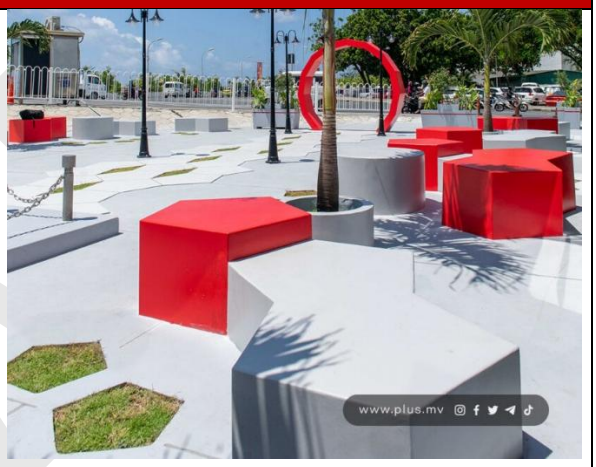
Strong current examples of harmoniously designed modern buildings include the Maldives National University main campus and VIA airport terminals:

**Examples of harmonious design with traditional or natural elements (blue-and-white, veranda with pillars, bougainvillea, ocean waves, Islamic geometric patterns)**



In contrast:

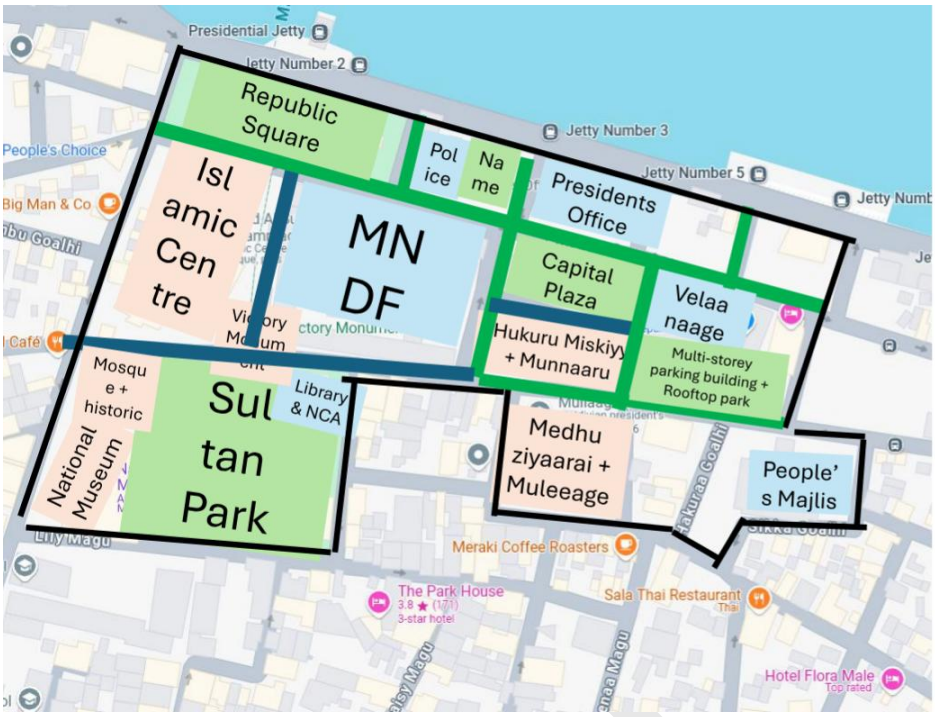
**Not harmonious to Maldivian identity - “color blocks” design motif**



## Designating the 'Old City' and capitol district

Making the core buildings more clearly an "old city" or landmark complex that can be viewed as a historical site, for example by making just the walkways between them be fully pedestrian shaded areas instead of having parking and motorcycles filling in the gaps, would also make a distinctive tourist site that contextualizes and symbolizes the rest of the city. This makes for much more cohesive branding of what makes Male' a unique site worth visiting.

These core buildings are also close to other important historical and symbolic buildings and institutions, including the President's Office, the offices of most government ministries, the People's Majlis, Republic Square, MNDF headquarters, Police building, Presidential Residence (Muleeaage), Republic Square, Islamic Centre, Sultan Park, key monuments, National Museum, National Library, National Art Gallery, and the key historical sites Hukuru Miskiyy, Munnaaru, Medhuziyaaraiy, and ancient cemeteries and mausoleums. This area as a whole being clearly named, labelled, and marked as one contiguous area for tourists to explore much more clearly defines Male' City's identity.




- Black line: outline of Old City to become a preserved and tourist site
- Dark blue lines: already pedestrian walkways with trees, shade, and no vehicles
- Dark green lines: can be gradually turned one by one over time to shaded pedestrian walkways with trees
- Light green squares: park spaces (including new Capital Plaza where PO, Velaanaage ministries, and Majlis staff can rest and build efficient ties, while also being a big tourist attraction)
- Blue squares: government buildings
- Peach squares: historical or cultural sites

## Old City

Memorable tourist attraction and reason for tourists going to resorts to also visit Male' (similar districts exist in other cities so familiar concept for tourists)

Having a "capital district" or "capital complex" where the government agencies are a collective complex and PO, Velaanaage and Majlis feel like a whole that works together

Locals to feel more in touch with Male' history (more able to understand how it used to be vs reclaimed and highly developed locations)

## Capital Plaza

- Huravee Building sites can be made into a beautiful shaded park and public square which brings everything together, especially the space between the three buildings
- That space includes Hukuru Miskiyy which puts the oldest symbol of the city and traditions at the heart of government symbolically
- People spending time in the square will be seeing the old and the new of the city all together
- Unique design elements that appeal to tourists and locals
- One of the first things any tourist coming to Male' will see

## Pedestrian-friendly

- About 35% of the streets within this area are already vehicle-free pedestrian areas
- Already pedestrian: walkway between Islamic Centre and MNDF, area between Islamic Centre and Sultan Park, sand pathway between Hukuru Miskiyy and old Huravee building area ("Capital Plaza", etc
- Gradually making remaining streets in the zone pedestrian-only
- Ameer Ahmed Magu area outside PO and street next to Majlis already has lots of trees and easy to make pedestrian-only

## Accessible transport

- Can create direct bus routes from across city and Hulhumale to directly by this area to encourage government employees to use public transport even for their own convenience
- Can have the e-bike docking stations and charging stations later to encourage all the core government employees to conveniently use e-bikes
- Lots of indoor parking in multi-storey building with a rooftop park in current Majlis parking area behind Hotel Jen (eventually)
- Pedestrian walkways are more wheelchair-friendly than roads

## Affordable, impactful, legacy

- This area would become symbolic of the city the way Buckingham Palace is for London, Capitol Building/White House is for Washington DC, etc
- Pedestrian streets is one of the lower-cost options for city redevelopment + is a good first step for other things like with streetscaping, shade structures, art projects, and other elements
- People will complain about driving streets for a while but will forget about it and appreciate the area in months

Gradually, this area can be more and more identified with being the "old city" and a symbolic area, through measures such as gradually fully pedestrianizing and shading the contiguous "capitol district" and having direct bus routes to and from the edge of the district (bus routes from Male' and Hulhumale' stopping at the corner by Velaanaage means that not only can office workers from all the major government offices located in the district be able to easily commute to and from the zone, reducing congestion and traffic to make up for the road closures under pedestrianization, but that major bus routes centering to the capitol district also highlights it more for tourists exploring the city as an important area.

The same general ideas apply for key sites in other islands or cities.